

"Freedom isn't worth having if it doesn't include the

Mahatma Gandhi

Freedom fighter 1869-1948

Dearest Dada,

First, a piece of news : you have made it to India's top 60.

And, then, a lark: I have been asked to present you in 700 words. I might explain heat in 70 words, or light in seven. Can the crisp writer in you please e-mail me that piece on yourself? You have, I am sure, a laptop wherever you are, to keep in touch with people humming like you did with your charkha. You did not waste cotton when spinning, you will write thriftily. Only you could have summed up the Indian elite's ignorance of the poor in 16 words of one syllable each: "Those in whose name we speak we do not know, and they do not know us". You wrote that in 1909; that stays true a hundred years later.

"A nameless fear has seized me that all is not well". You wrote that in June 1946 when we stood at freedom's door. That, too, holds 60 years on. Yet, you could transform fear into energy. An odd energy, sometimes. One of the unusual things you did was to adopt countless sons and daughters, feeling for them, with them, drawing them into your restless intensities.

Which is why millions took to you as to a father. How did you manage, day after packed day, to write letters—from prison, train, wherever—to scores of people? The children of your flesh—Harilal, the eldest, and his three brothers—saw large portions of your heart and time diverted to your adopted

children. They were wonderful sons, those four. They realised, not without effort, that you and your adopted children constituted a mighty family at work.

If you and your 'birth' family, had clung marsupially to each other, would India have been changed and the world shaken as it was? It would not have. You saved the coppers of a householder to lavish gold on humanity. You renounced to redeem.

But you were not always a sombre renunciate, were you? You told one of your adopted sons Dattatreya 'Kaka' Kalelkar of two 'loves' renouncing which you regretted. One, the love of travel. You must have meant travel to far off lands, for no one criss-crossed India as you did. The other—joy from literature. I wish you had expanded on that and on what. Before my parents Devadas and Lakshmi got married, you told Nana. Discussing their romance, you said to Rajaji, your eyes shining, that the *Ramayana* too was a love story.

Speaking of romance did you ever read *Anna Karenina*? Or did you confine yourself, where Tolstoy was concerned, only to *The Kingdom of God Within You* and *Confessions*? I hope you did not, for ever so often, reading you, I run into sentences that could come from a novelist. You, who saw into the heart of a large nation (actually two nations—India and Britain) could also sketch people vividly. You have described your landlady's daughter who took you, then a 20-year-old student in London, to the lovely hills

around Ventnor. "She was flying like a bird...in spite of her high-heeled boots, this sprightly young lady of 25 dashed down the hill like an arrow...I somehow managed to scramble to the bottom. She loudly laughed 'bravo' and shamed me all the more...."

Today, your ideas dart like arrows around the world. Your scorching love shames brute force, shows up hypocrisy and shakes up callousness towards fellow beings, towards nature. And humanity shouts bravo.

There are those who say you solved some problems, left others unresolved. They could well say that of God. You were a human being like any other. But gifted. Gifted with an ability to test your powerful intuition against the touchstones of love and reason. The test cleared, you turned those intuitions into convictions and, whenever needed, you 'walked alone'. Which perhaps is why not a day passes without someone somewhere in the world wondering, breath held in awe, how you did it.

"Top 60? No, in the last six." Your e-mail reply comes in. I asked for 700 words, you have said it all in just seven.

Pranams to Dadi-Ba and to you, Dada, with my faith everlastingly.

Gopu

By Gopalkrishna Gandhi

The author is Gandhi's youngest grandson. He is currently the Governor of West Bengal